Fourth Sunday of Advent & Christmas Greetings from Fr. Craig Lusk

Dear Friends in Christ,

During the Advent Season, we heard the summoning of the prophets foretelling of the Messiah. Those prophets are: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Haggai and St. John the Baptist.

Although we do not know the actual date of Jesus' birth, the earliest liturgical observance of the coming of our Lord appears to be around January 6th in the East, and it was more focused on the theological mystery of the manifestation of God in the flesh than on the historical date of his birth. This is still the case in many Eastern Rite Catholic and Orthodox Churches.

The Church in Rome began a feast of Jesus' birth on December 25th, possibly to replace the pagan feast of the Unconquered Sun or the Winter Solstice. December 25th became fixed by Rome and other Christians in the West after St. Francis of Assisi's popularization of the Christmas Creche.



I am wishing and praying for all those attending one of our Christmas Liturgies at St. Mary and St. John Parishes that your hearts may be filled with joy as we celebrate the birth of our Savior, Jesus Christ.

We contemplate Mother and child on this "silent and holy night," and as we gaze at this tiny, delicate infant held in his mother's arms, we believe and confess that here is our very God, the Infinite and Omnipotent Being who made the universe, the wonders of nature, and the complex creature that is the human person.

He makes himself present and accessible to us in a form that melts even our cold, sinful hearts. As the prophet Isaiah speaks throughout the Advent season: "Do not be afraid, I am your Savior."

"A Savior has been born!" Let us hear these words anew. May we humbly admit that we indeed need a Savior and welcome Him into our hearts, homes and our lives.

A Very Merry Christmas To All!

In His love,
Fr. Craig